From the Insane Asylum

By Joseph Kaufer

YOUNG MAN/WOMAN: *(with arms wrapped as if in a straightjacket, voice these words in an ominous tone)*

I in a straitjacket – you think that frightful?
What do you think I was in
Before I came here? (#11, page 18)

SOCIETY RESPONDS: *(assume a reasonable voice of society in response to this question)*

Better to be locked up now,
Than in full adult awareness collide
With courts, police, neighbors, juries, lawyers,
Humiliated ashamed relatives,
And come here stunned, frightened, from another world
Which denies and derides you;
Better to come now, child,
And be at once among your own. (#64, pg 57)

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DOCTOR'S ANALYSIS: *(assume the persona of a medical professional)*

Since animals in the wild have no psychoses,
What is there that sickens the mind in human society,
Clogs the intellect, dries up the emotions,
Causes people to agonize over nothing,
Scream, weep, shout, become mute, rigid, overexcited?
I had best not say it: there are two sacred institutions
That will instantly take from me my professional
position. (#117, pg 77)

INTRODUCTION

The most influential institution that leads to anti-social behaviors in our society is THE FAMILY. What? Yes - not ill-intentioned – but very damaging.

*See . . . Some parents are obsessed with the desire to ensure that their kids never have to face struggle, inconvenience, discomfort, or disappointment. Mistakes are swept under the table, excuses are made and bad behavior is explained away in the most positive terms possible. In fact, if their child **does** do something wrong, these parents are adept in turning the tables so that their little darling is the victim of an unjust and unreasonable society. Armed with verbal smart bombs,*

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they are quick to blast away at anyone who sets high standards for behavior, morality, or achievement. And over time, society is left with adults who take no personal responsibility for their actions, who appreciate nothing and who acknowledge no authority. Effectively these parents are creating a generation of monsters. It's insanity to the nth degree. And our educational systems, businesses, courts and psychologists are left to deal with the aftermath.

This collection of poems by Joseph Kaufer . . . . From the Insane Asylum spotlights the creation of these asocial "monsters."

OUR SON: The Parents Speak for Their Boy
(Use two voices for this poem, dividing the lines between both a mother and father persona)

When he slept on the floor

and watered the ceiling,

That was an idiosyncrasy.

When he stayed out of school

And spent two days in a cistern, --

You know lots of kids play hookey.

When on the way home from the grocery

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He dropped the eggs on the sidewalk, one by one,

And on arriving locked the cat in the refrigerator,

That was just his own little humor.

When he found his parents' life savings,

And went out and bought five thousand dollars worth of bubble gum

And distributed it all by the handful

Among all the children of the town,

That was only a fancy, although painful.

When he slapped the school teacher

And pushed in the principal's nose,

Saying it was too long

- Well, it ***is*** too long.

Why can't they leave our son alone?

When he got a job at the grocery store

And spilled the molasses all over the floor

So the customers could slide more quickly in through the

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door,
That was genius unappreciated.

When he shot the cow with the borrowed gun,
Then chased away the farmer,
He didn't know it wasn't open season,
And he only did it for fun;
And if he chased away the farmer
He ***must*** have had a good reason.

When he pulled the gasoline truck's spigots open
When the driver stepped out of sight
And tossed a lighted match into it
To see if it would really ignite,
That was just scientific curiosity,
There was no reason for the man to get so wild;
It just shows in what direction our boy's talent is bent,
He's really a talented child.

When he drove away in the Police Chief's car,
And turned the siren on, and smashed it up against

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An ornamental light pole,
Isn't it enough that we paid for it all,
Do they have to torture his soul?

Why can't they leave our son alone?

When he took all the money
Out of the other boy's pocket,
He having spent all his own,
The inequality should be evident to all,
He was only trying to Make An Adjustment.

When he pulled the little girls' panties down
To see what little girls look like,
And then exposed himself to ***their*** interested sight,
Any psychologist in town
Would tell you, that is only Normal.

When he was found by the police walking the streets
Instead of at the fruit stand where he had obtained
employment,

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And all the fruit man's day's receipts
Were found in the pockets of our boy's pants, --
He hadn't done anything dishonest,
He was only learning Finance.

When he set fire to the grain warehouse
To see the fire engines run, --
He ran no faster than anyone else,
Everybody likes a good fire.

Why can't they leave our son alone?

When he told the judge before whom he was brought
That the judge looked like a pig
And that his wife was a female dog,
That was no more than the artist in him.
- For the judge is heavy, like a hog,
And his wife does resemble a Griffon.

When the psychologist appointed by the court
Tried to interview our son,

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And all he would say was, blah, blah, blah, blah,
Oink, oink, oink, oink,
People just don't ***understand*** him.

And when they told how he
Grabbed the old woman from behind in the dark
And pulled her down
And tried to roll her around in the alley, --
Why, all that boy needs is ***love***.

Why can't they leave our son alone? (#164, pg 116)

YOUNG MAN/WOMAN: *(with arms wrapped as if in a straightjacket, voice these words in an ominous voice over your shoulder)*

When my mother lay on the kitchen floor,
Begging me not to stab her more,
I could not feel or show her any mercy,
I could not forgive her for having made me.
(#199, pg 150)

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DOCTOR'S ANALYSIS: *(assume the persona of a medical professional)*

Of all the creatures that on this earth creep, swim or
fly,
This, the so-called human is the only one
That kills for sport,
Seeks importance at the expense of others' humiliations,
Wages war for sheer aggrandizement,
Acquires psychoses in the natural state,
Becomes an egotistical burden on impoverished relations.

For us to eliminate all the malign faults and divergencies
of this species,
Why, would be required the devising of the elimination
of the race! (#277, page 202)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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